

An aerial photograph of the coastal town of Playa del Carmen, showing a mix of greenery, buildings, and the turquoise ocean under a blue sky with scattered clouds.

A LOCAL-LIVING GUIDE

Playa del Carmen & the Riviera Maya

A walkable beach town on the Caribbean, with cenotes, Maya cities, turtle bays and colonial towns an hour or two away — a month of living on the coast, with day trips and short escapes, not just a week at a resort.

ANDREW & SYLVAIN · EDITION OF SEPTEMBER 2026

The areas

The first four chapters are Playa del Carmen itself — the south Quinta, the calmer north, gated Playacar and the local side where prices halve. The next seven are day trips and one-night escapes, from Cozumel and the cenote coast to Tulum, Cobá, Chichén Itzá and Cancún. Mérida, Bacalar, Holbox and the flamingo coast close the guide as 2–3 day extensions.



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Seasons, sargassum & money

When to go

December–March is dry and 25–30°C, with a 26°C sea — peak season, busiest from Christmas to New Year and at Easter (21 Mar–4 Apr 2027). April–May are hot and dry. June–August are humid with afternoon showers. September–October are the wettest months and the peak of hurricane season (1 June–30 Nov) — quiet and cheap, but keep plans flexible. November is lovely and good value.

Sargassum

Brown seaweed drifts onto the Caribbean beaches from about May to September (2026 has been a moderate-to-heavy year); November to March is usually clear. Check the town's daily beach “semáforo”, howisthesargassum.com or sargassummonitoring.com. Playacar and the north end often fare better, and Isla Mujeres, Holbox and Bacalar are rarely affected.

Money & tipping

Pay in pesos — dollars get a poor rate. Use ATMs inside banks or malls and always **decline the “conversion” offer**. Cards work in restaurants; carry cash for colectivos, taxis, markets, cenotes and ruins. Tip 10–15% in restaurants (check for “servicio incluido”), MXN 20 a drink at a bar, 10–15% for guides.

Visitax & entry

Quintana Roo's visitor tax is about MXN 290 per person, once per visit: pay only at visitax.gob.mx (never a third-party site) and keep the QR code — it's checked on departure at Cancún. Canadians fill in the digital tourist card (FMM) online on arrival and keep a copy; stays of up to 180 days are possible.

Safety & health

Canada rates all of Mexico “high degree of caution”; Quintana Roo is not on its avoid list. Problems in Playa are mostly petty theft, scams and pushy sellers, with occasional cartel-linked shootings that rarely involve visitors. Stay on lit streets, use Uber or a called taxi at night, keep off the beach after dark, and stay away from drugs. Don't drink tap water. Dengue is rising this autumn — use DEET or icaridin in the daytime. Hospiten and Costamed are the private hospitals; buy travel medical insurance.

Ruins, cenotes & language

Archaeological sites open about 8:00–17:00; free Sundays apply only to Mexican residents, so go on weekdays. Many cenotes ban all sunscreen and repellent, and require a shower first. A little Spanish goes far — *la cuenta, por favor, sin hielo, mi esposo* — and in Maya, *Bix a beel?* (how are you?) and *Dios bo'otik* (thank you). Plugs and voltage are the same as Canada.



Quinta Avenida — Dennis Sylvester Hurd · CC BY 2.0

This autumn: peak hurricane and rain season to the end of October · Day of the Dead 31 Oct–2 Nov, with Xcaret's Festival de Vida y Muerte · the Riviera Maya Jazz Festival has not returned since 2023 · Holbox's whale-shark season ended mid-September · dengue cases rising — use repellent.

Colectivos, buses, the Tren Maya & ferries

From the airports

From Cancún (CUN), the ADO bus runs about every 30–60 minutes to Playa's Quinta Avenida terminal in 1 h 15 (about MXN 260–270; buy at the kiosk, cash or card). A private transfer is about US\$95 per car. Air Canada and Air Transat also fly Montreal–Tulum (TQO), about an hour south by ADO or taxi.

ADO buses

First-class ADO (and cheaper Mayab) buses leave from the Turística terminal on the Quinta at Av. Juárez and the Alterna terminal at Av. 20 and Calle 12, for Tulum, Cobá, Valladolid, Mérida, Bacalar and Cancún. Buy at the counter; the website often rejects foreign cards.

Taxis & apps

No meters: taxis use zone fares, roughly MXN 60–100 in town — agree the price first and pay in pesos. Uber, DiDi and inDrive operate legally in Quintana Roo but may ask you to walk away from taxi stands.

Colectivos

The white shared vans on Highway 307 are the local way to the coast: Puerto Morelos about MXN 30–40, Akumal 35–45, Tulum 50–70, Cancún 55–60. They leave when full, about every 5–10 minutes from 6:00 to 23:00, from Calle 1 Sur by Chedraui or Calle 2 Norte at Av. 20 — ask locally. Say your stop by name; flag one down on the highway to come back.

The Tren Maya

Playa's station is about 6 km inland (MXN 55 shuttle from the ADO terminal, or a taxi). Approximate foreign fares: Cancún airport 200–230, Tulum about 210, Valladolid about 500, Chichén Itzá about 620, Mérida about 960, Bacalar 920–1,120. Only a few trains a day; fares were changed in 2026, so check trenmaya.gob.mx, book only there, and bring your passports. Allow slack — there have been delays.

A car & the ferry

Rent one for the Ruta de los Cenotes, Cobá, Valladolid and Holbox, with full Mexican liability insurance. Watch for *topes* (speed bumps); at the pump check it starts at zero and count your change. Ultramar and Winjet sail to Cozumel roughly hourly, 6:00–23:00, in 45 minutes (about MXN 200–330 one way).



The Tren Maya — Unknown authorUnknown author · Public domain

LGBTQ+ Playa & the Riviera Maya

The climate

Same-sex marriage has been legal across Mexico since 2022 (Quintana Roo since 2012), discrimination is banned, and a Canadian marriage is recognised — “mi esposo” at hotel check-in is routine. Playa is very mixed gay/straight, and holding hands on the Quinta, at beach clubs and in Tulum’s hotel zone draws little notice. Be more discreet in Maya villages, on colectivos, in Valladolid and at rural cenotes.

Pride & events

Playa’s Marcha de la Diversidad was 28 June 2026 — small, local and friendly; Cancún’s was 16 May 2026. 2027 dates are not announced; expect May–June. Arena week (late Jan–early Feb) is a big circuit party: busy, loud and expensive. Day of the Dead turns the Quinta into a costume party.

Beyond Playa

Cozumel has Pose Bar; Tulum has the Red Room drag bar (Wed–Sun, late); Cancún has 11:11 Club downtown and the BackDoor’s Sunday drag brunch in the Hotel Zone, with Playa Delfines as the gay beach. Mérida has the peninsula’s liveliest scene — Bernardette Show Bar for cabaret drag.

Where to go

Calle 28 is the hub: the beach just north of Mamitas, and **Sirenas**, an easy-going open-air drag and karaoke bar that suits a couple at sunset.

Provenza on Calle 32 is the main club, with drag shows (daily from 20:00, cover about MXN 200). Bartola on Calle 4 is a mixed mezcal bar. Dominatrix on Calle 12 Bis is a male strip club. Club 69 has closed, though old maps still show it.

Hotels

The Palm at Playa (adults-only, rooftop pool) and Hotel Reina Roja are gay-popular; Thompson Playa del Carmen’s rooftop draws a mixed crowd. In Mérida, the gay-owned Ochenta y Dos B&B; in Tulum, Hotel Bardot.

Relaxed favourites & care

A sundowner at Sirenas, then an early drag show at Provenza; the Sunday afternoon crowd on the Calle 28 beach; a long lunch at Axiote. Meet app contacts in public first, never leave drinks unattended, and use Uber at night. Check a venue’s Instagram the week you go — the scene changes fast.

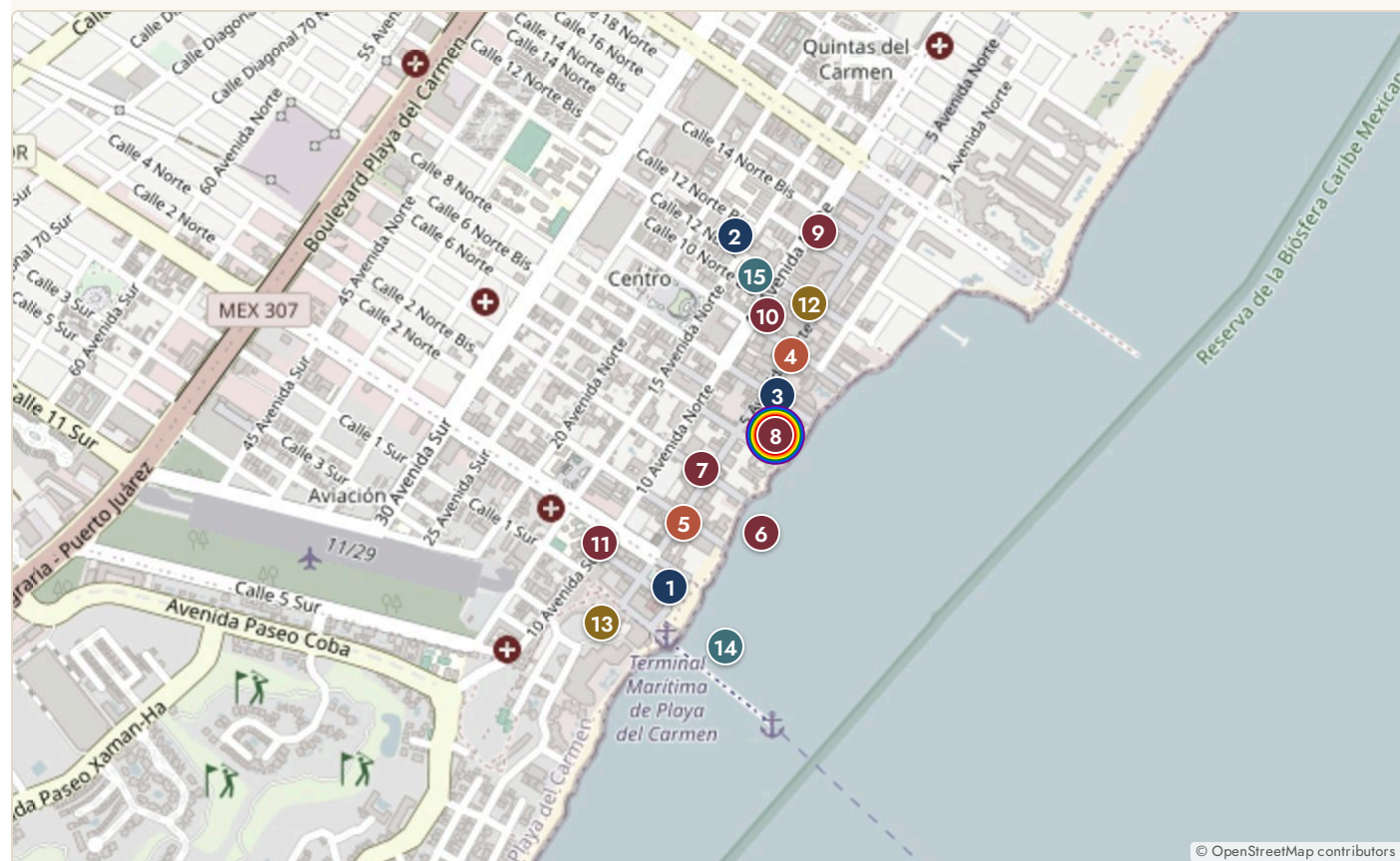


The beach at Calle 28 — Alfonso Buscemi · CC BY 3.0

Throughout this guide, the  badge and rainbow-ringed map pins mark gay and LGBTQ+-friendly places, including the gay beaches in Playa and Cancún.

I Centro & the South Quinta

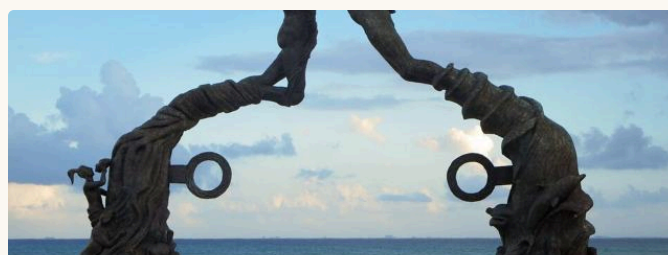
Quinta Avenida starts at the ferry pier and Parque Fundadores: pedestrian, busy with day-trippers, and lined with shops and bars as far as Calle 12. Step one block inland to Av. 10 and Av. 15 and the side streets turn into cafés, taquerías and the small gay strip on Calle 4.



- Sights, Ruins & Museums
- Cafés, Bakeries & Ice Cream
- Restaurants & Bars
- Markets & Food Shops
- Shopping & Crafts
- Beaches, Cenotes & Walks
- LGBTQ+-friendly

SIGHTS, RUINS & MUSEUMS

- 1 Parque Fundadores & the Portal Maya** — The bronze arch where Av. Juárez meets the sea is the town's symbol. The Voladores de Papantla spin down their pole here most afternoons and evenings — tip about MXN 50.
- 2 Nuestra Señora del Carmen** — The small white parish church on the park that gave the town its name. Sunday-evening Mass spills out onto the square; 16 July is her feast day.
- 3 Museo Frida Kahlo Riviera Maya** — Quinta Avenida at Calle 8. A biographical museum of reproductions, photographs and letters rather than original paintings — a good hour on a rainy afternoon (about MXN 300–420).



David Stanley from Nanaimo, Canada · CC BY 2.0

CAFÉS, BAKERIES & ICE CREAM

- 4 Anita Gelato** — Quinta at Calle 10, the chain's first Mexican shop (late 2025): dozens of flavours, open until midnight, 1:00 at weekends.

- 5 **Ah Cacao** — Playa's own chocolate café, with branches at Calle 2, Constituyentes and Calle 38: Maya hot chocolate with chili, iced cacao, brownies. Open about 7:15–23:30.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 6 **La Tarraya** — On the sand at Calle 2, billed as Playa's oldest restaurant: whole fish grilled *tikin-xic* style in achiote, cold beer, honest prices. Go at lunch for the sea view.
- 7 **Carboncitos** — Calle 4 between the Quinta and Av. 10: charcoal-grilled tacos and *alambres* (grilled meat, peppers and onion under melted cheese). Casual, mid-priced, busy in the evening.
- 8 **Bartola**  — A mezcal and cocktail bar on Calle 4, the unofficial gay strip; a mixed, relaxed crowd and a good first drink before a drag show.
- 9 **Aldea Corazón** — Quinta between Calle 14 and 14 Bis: a garden courtyard round a pool, lantern-lit at night. Go for the setting and a cocktail rather than the (pricey) food.
- 10 **Kaxapa Factory** — Calle 10 between the Quinta and Av. 10: Venezuelan arepas and *cachapas* (sweet-corn pancakes) — a cheap, cheerful break from tacos.
- 11 **Las Quekas** — Handmade blue-corn quesadillas with *tinga*, squash blossom or *huitlacoche*, about MXN 30–40 each. Cash only; there's another branch on Av. 10 Sur.



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SHOPPING & CRAFTS

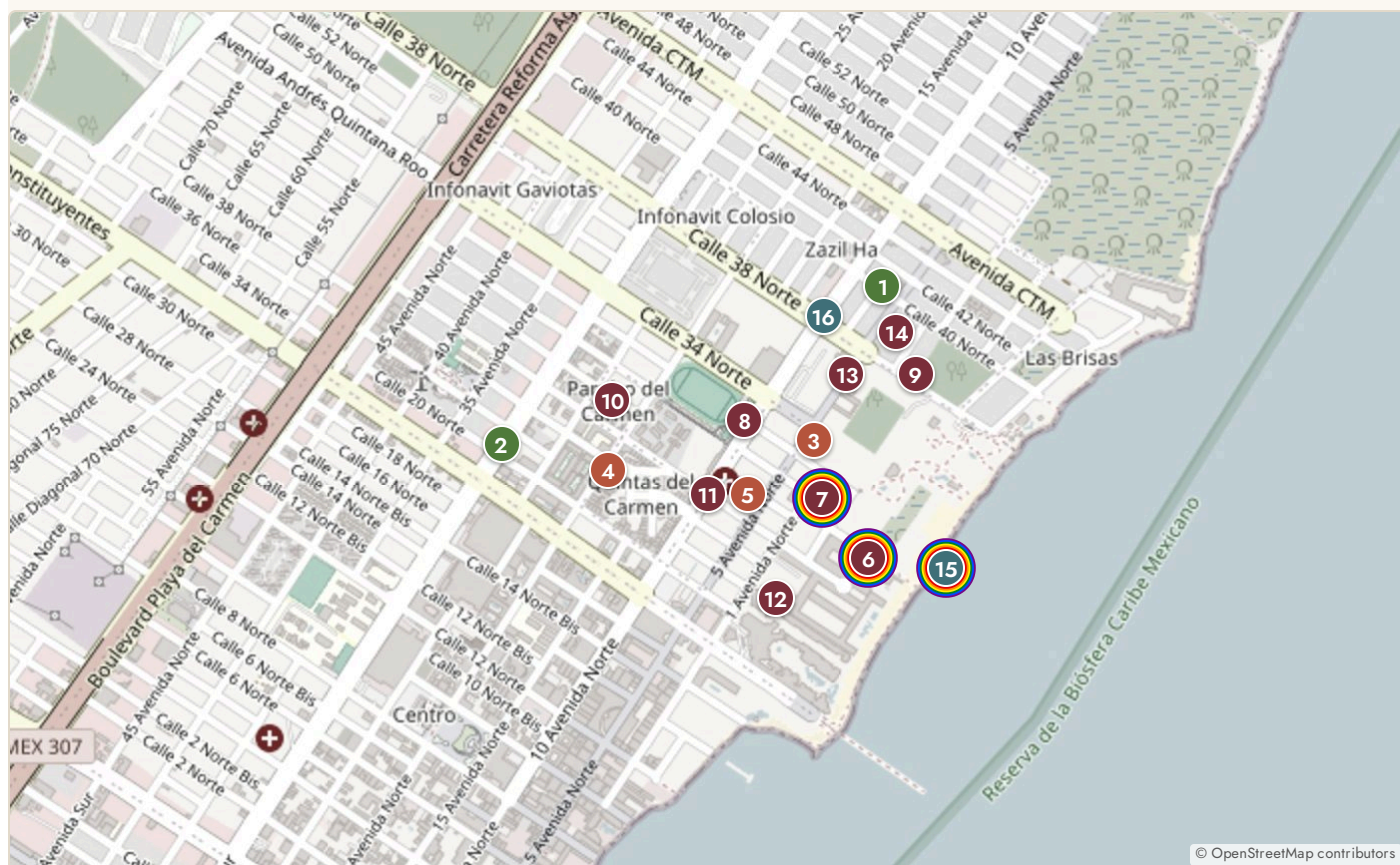
- 12 **Calle Corazón** — The pedestrian lane off the Quinta between Calle 12 and 14 with small galleries and design shops — the least tacky block of the south Quinta.
- 13 **Il Quinto Cavaliere** — A tiny independent bookshop on Calle 1 Sur with used books in Italian, Spanish and some English. Hours are irregular — check its Facebook page.

BEACHES, CENOTES & WALKS

- 14 **The ferry pier & the town beach** — The Ultramar and Winjet boats to Cozumel leave from here roughly hourly. Buy only at the company booths, never from touts. The beach either side is busy and narrow; the better sand is north of Calle 28 or south in Playacar.
- 15 **Calle 12 by night** — The loud, young club block: Coco Bongo's Vegas-style show and big dance bars. Worth a walk-by at 22:00; for a night out, Calle 28–32 suits better.

2 North Quinta, Calle 38 & Zazil-Ha

North of Constituyentes the Quinta calms down into restaurants and cafés, and the streets inland — nicknamed Little Italy for the Italians and Argentines who settled here — are where many winter residents rent. Calle 28 has the gay beach and bars; Zazil-Ha, around Calle 38–48, is quiet, leafy and close to the sand.



- Sights, Ruins & Museums ● Cafés, Bakeries & Ice Cream ● Restaurants & Bars ● Markets & Food Shops ● Shopping & Crafts
- Beaches, Cenotes & Walks ● LGBTQ+-friendly

MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- 1 **El Pirata** — Calle 40 between the Quinta and Av. 10: a fish market that cooks. Choose your fish at the counter and pay a small fee to have it grilled or fried.
- 2 **DAC Verduras y Frutas** — Av. 30 between Constituyentes and Calle 22: the nearest thing to a market in town — produce, cheese, bread, an organic corner. About 7:00–22:00; Sundays to 14:00. Mega (Soriana) is across Constituyentes for everything else.



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CAFÉS, BAKERIES & ICE CREAM

- 3 **Chez Céline** — Quinta at Calle 34: a French bakery for almond croissants, crêpes and breakfast. Full by 9:00.

- 4 **Choux Choux** — Av. 20 at Calle 24: French pastries, quiche and brunch on a shady residential corner — popular with Little Italy's residents.
- 5 **Vika** — Av. 10 between Calle 30 and 32: Argentine *medialunas* and cakes, with another branch on Av. 15.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 6 **Sirenas**  — Calle 28 near Mamitas: an open-air terrace with neon, cheap drinks, shrimp tacos, karaoke and drag. Daily 16:00–2:30 — the relaxed sunset drink after the beach.
- 7 **Provenza Club**  — Calle 32 Norte #69, between the Quinta and Av. 10: Playa's main gay club, with a rooftop, drag shows, karaoke and go-go dancers. Daily 20:00–3:00; cover about MXN 200. Go early for the show.
- 8 **Axiote** — Calle 34 between the Quinta and Av. 10 — Michelin Bib Gourmand, the only Michelin-recognised table in town. Duck tacos, fish birria, peanut mole. Tue–Sun 12:00–23:00; reserve for dinner. Your special-night pick.
- 9 **La Perla Pixan** — Just off the Quinta on Calle 34: cochinita and duck tacos, a long mezcal list and live music. Upper-mid prices.
- 10 **Los Aguachiles** — Calle 34 at Av. 25: a Sinaloa-style seafood palapa for shrimp aguachile, tuna tostadas and marlin tacos. Full of locals at 14:00–15:00.
- 11 **Maison Oh Lala!** — Av. 10 between Calle 28 and 30: about ten tables of French-leaning seafood and tasting plates in its new home. Reservations essential.
- 12 **Harry's** — The big splurge: dry-aged steaks and a raw bar in a garden round a cenote. Expect MXN 2,000+ each; reserve.
- 13 **La Cueva del Chango** — Calle 38 between the Quinta and the sea: a jungle-garden terrace for a long breakfast — chilaquiles, fruit plates, good coffee.
- 14 **Amate 38** — Yucatecan cooking on Calle 38 — *sopa de lima*, *poc chuc* and cochinita — in a relaxed room near the beach.



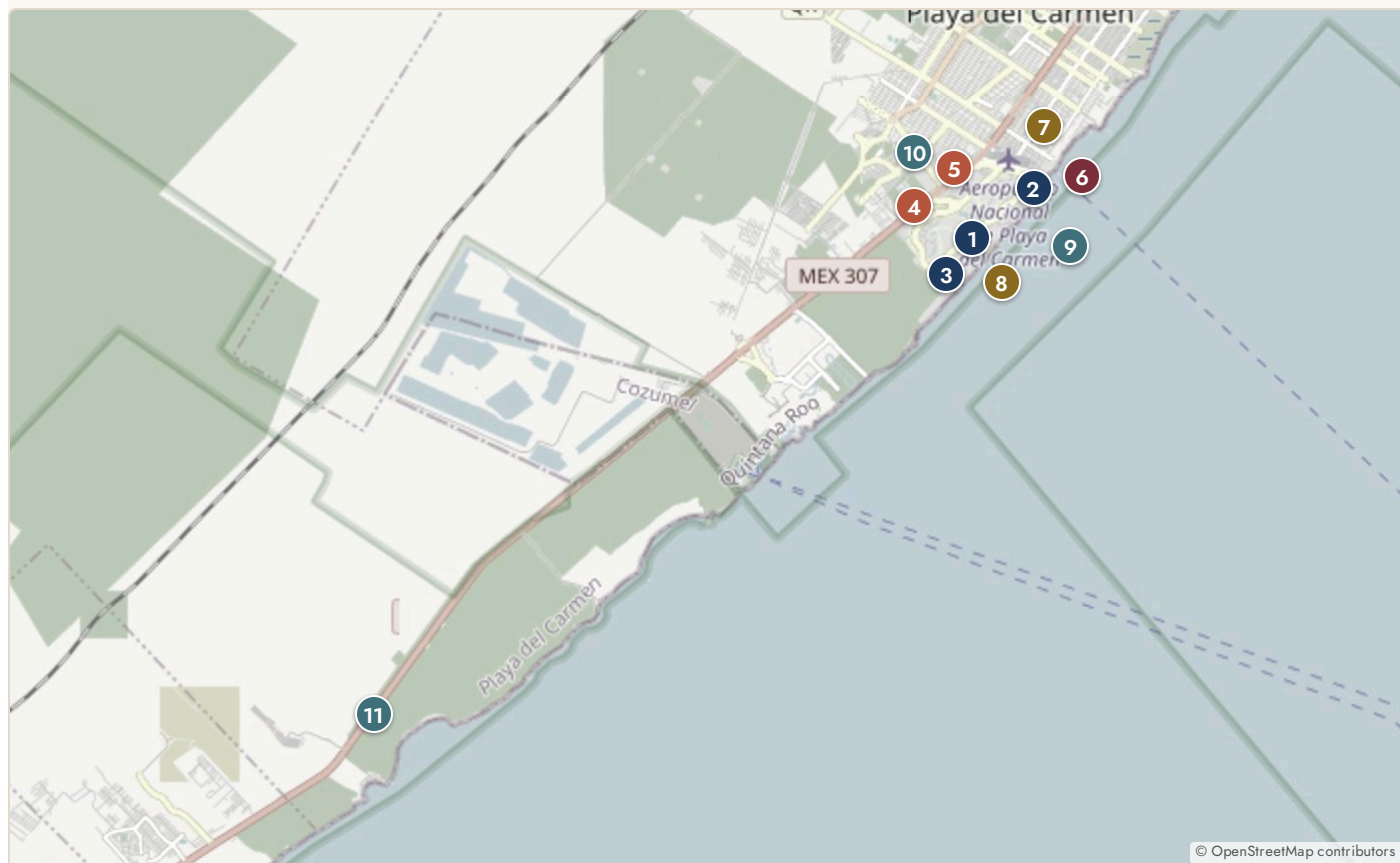
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BEACHES, CENOTES & WALKS

- 15 **Mamitas & the Calle 28 beach**  — Playa's best-known beach club (minimum spend about US\$25–30). The LGBTQ+ stretch is just north of it, by the wooden lifeguard tower — busiest on Sunday afternoons; the sand is free and loungers are for rent.
- 16 **Calle 38 beach & the quieter clubs** — At the end of Calle 38, a calmer beach with Kool Beach (about US\$25 minimum, better loungers) and Lido (free entry, pay as you go). The street from Av. 30 to the sea is the neighbourhood's food row.

3 AREA Playacar

South of the ferry pier, Playacar is a gated, landscaped estate: Phase 1 is villas and condo-hotels on the beach, Phase 2 wraps round the golf course and the big all-inclusives. It's quiet, green and full of coatis, iguanas and small Maya ruins — lovely for walking, dead in the evening, and 10 minutes from the Quinta from Phase 1.



- Sights, Ruins & Museums ● Cafés, Bakeries & Ice Cream ● Restaurants & Bars ● Markets & Food Shops ● Shopping & Crafts
- Beaches, Cenotes & Walks ● LGBTQ+-friendly

SIGHTS, RUINS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Xaman-Ha Aviary** — Paseo Xaman-Ha, Phase 2: more than 45 native species — flamingos, toucans, macaws — in a walk-through jungle garden. Daily 9:00–17:00, about MXN 300. Go at 9:00, when the birds are most active.
- 2 **The Playacar ruins** — Small Post-Classic temples (about 1200–1550) of Xaman-Ha, the Maya port for Cozumel pilgrims, scattered by the Phase 1 entrance and along the Phase 2 path. Free and unfenced.

- 3 **Playacar golf** — The 18-hole Robert von Hagge course (now Hard Rock Golf Club Riviera Maya), carved through the jungle. Green fees change often; book tee times online.



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CAFÉS, BAKERIES & ICE CREAM

- 4 **Bendito Pecado** — Paseo Xaman-Ha at Calle Chichén
Itzá: artisan gelato and affogato after the aviary.
- 5 **La Brioché de Playa** — Opposite Bendito Pecado: French bread, chocolatinas and croque-madame for a Phase 2 breakfast.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 6 **Lara y Luca & Casa Sofía** — Just outside the gate on Calle 7 Sur: Lara y Luca for brunch, Casa Sofía for Italian with live music some evenings.



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SHOPPING & CRAFTS

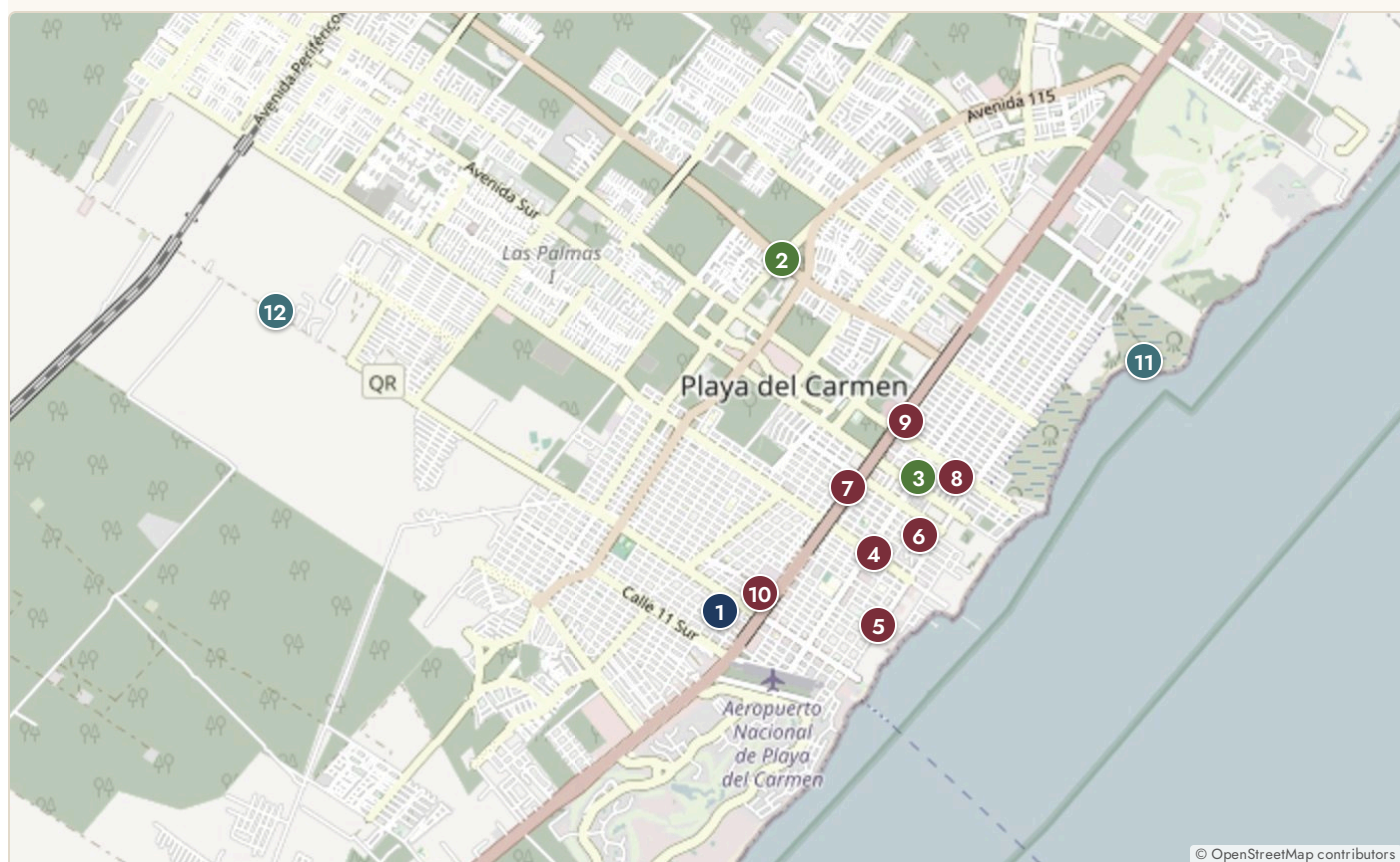
- 7 **Paseo del Carmen** — The shaded open-air mall at the Phase 1 gate, two minutes from the ferry: boutiques, cafés and ice cream when the Quinta is too hot.
- 8 **Plaza Playacar** — Paseo Xaman-Ha opposite the Riu: pharmacy, deli, currency exchange and a few good Mexican craft shops.

BEACHES, CENOTES & WALKS

- 9 **Playacar beach** — Wider and emptier than the town beach, with reef snorkelling offshore; public access about 100 m inside the Phase 1 gate. Often less sargassum than Centro.
- 10 **The Phase 2 path** — About 6 km of paved path looping past the ruins and golf course — best at 7:00 for birds, coatis and cool air.
- 11 **Punta Venado** — Twenty minutes south by taxi: a quiet eco-cove with snorkelling, kayaks and horses, on a day pass — a calm alternative to the town beach clubs.

4 The Local Side: Av. 30, Colosio & Punta Esmeralda

West of Av. 20 prices halve and menus switch to Spanish: this is where taxi drivers, hotel staff and Mexican families eat, shop and go to the beach. Colosio, north of Calle 50, is a real working neighbourhood with a Sunday street market and the town's favourite family beach.



- Sights, Ruins & Museums ● Cafés, Bakeries & Ice Cream ● Restaurants & Bars ● Markets & Food Shops ● Shopping & Crafts
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SIGHTS, RUINS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Parque La Ceiba** — Av. 60 at Calle 1 Sur: a community cultural park round a sacred ceiba tree, with workshops, a library and a Saturday craft market.



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MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- 2 **Tianguis de la Colosio** — Around Calle 56–58 on Sunday mornings: produce, clothes, second-hand everything, and quesadillas and *barbacoa* from the stalls. Taxi there, bring small notes, mind your pockets.
- 3 **Super Aki & the taco stands** — The cheapest supermarket in town (Av. 30, 7:00–23:00). In the evenings, taco stands gather outside the Av. 30 / Calle 40 branch: El Ingrato's two-for-one pastor, El Chito at MXN 12–15 a taco.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

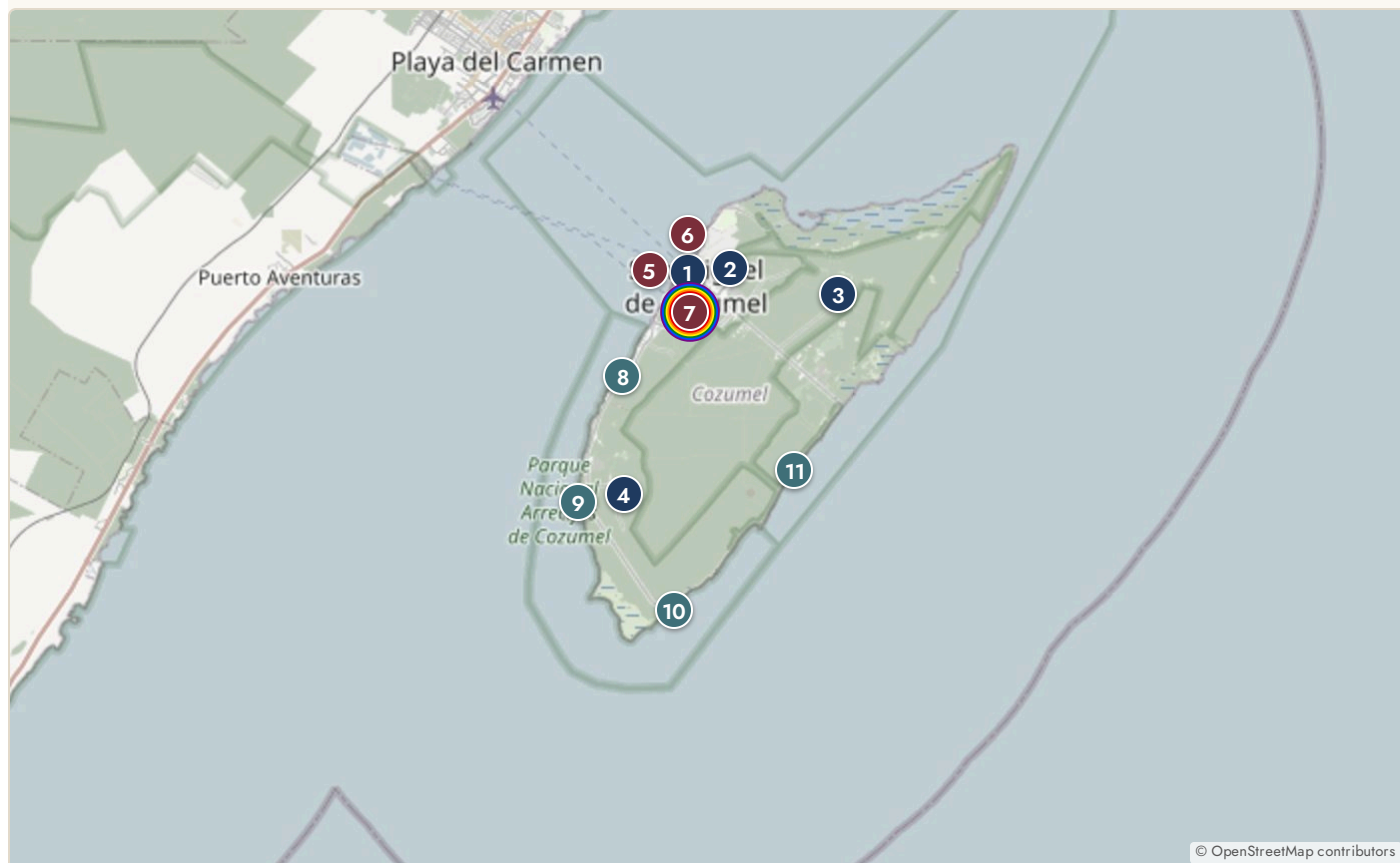
- 4 **El Fogón** — Av. 30 Norte: the classic for tacos al pastor carved off the spit, and a *gringa* (flour tortilla with cheese and pastor). About MXN 25–30 a taco; queues after 20:00.
- 5 **Don Sirloin** — Av. 10 and on Constituyentes at Av. 25: shawarma-style sirloin and arrachera tacos with pineapple-jalapeño salsa, 11:30–22:30.
- 6 **El Gran Taco de Playa** — Av. 30 between Calle 24 and 26: fifteen stews (*guisados*) on handmade tortillas, mornings only until sold out around 14:00. Closed Monday.
- 7 **Birria de la 30** — Crispy birria tacos with a cup of consommé for dipping — small room, worth the wait.
- 8 **Rincón Yucateco** — Calle 46 between Av. 10 and 15: *panuchos*, *salbutes* and cochinita for breakfast and lunch — Yucatán home cooking for a few pesos.
- 9 **La Bomba Jarocho** — Av. 30 at Calle 34 Bis: Veracruz seafood — shrimp-and-cheese *cazuela*, *cocteles* — for a mostly local crowd.
- 10 **Alux** — Av. Juárez near the highway: dinner inside a real underground cavern, lit in colours. The most spectacular special-occasion room in town; reserve.

BEACHES, CENOTES & WALKS

- 11 **Punta Esmeralda** — The end of Calle 88: a cold cenote channel runs into the sea, making a shallow natural pool. Free, with a playground and washrooms. Mexican families at weekends; weekday mornings are ideal. Bring shade and water.
- 12 **Chaak Tun cenote** — The closest cenotes to town, about 15 minutes by taxi west on Av. Juárez: two cave pools with light beams, visited with a guide.

5 Cozumel

A 45-minute ferry ride across the channel, Cozumel's town, San Miguel, is a relaxed cruise port with a seafront promenade and good family restaurants a few streets back. Beyond it, the island has calm snorkel water on the west coast, a wild and empty Caribbean east coast, and lagoons at the southern tip. Rent a car for the 65 km loop.



SIGHTS, RUINS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **The Malecón & Plaza Juárez** — The main square faces the ferry pier: clock tower, family life in the evening, the shopping streets behind. Walk the seafront Av. Rafael Melgar at sunset, after the cruise crowds leave.
- 2 **Museo de la Isla** — Av. Melgar between Calle 4 and 6 Norte: a small island-history museum with a rooftop café over the sea.
- 3 **San Gervasio** — Off the cross-island road: the Maya sanctuary of Ixchel, goddess of fertility, to which women canoed from the mainland. Little shade — go at opening.

- 4 **El Cedral** — Inland from the south coast road: the island's oldest settlement, a small Maya structure beside the Santa Cruz chapel, and craft stalls.



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RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 5 **Kinta** — Av. 5 Sur downtown: modern Mexican cooking in a garden patio — book dinner if you stay the night.
- 6 **Casa Denis** — Calle 1 Sur by the square: a long-running Yucatecan family restaurant — order the cochinita pibil.
- 7 **Pose Bar**  — Cozumel's gay bar, in town, with drinks, drag and dancing — check its social media for event nights before planning a late ferry.

BEACHES, CENOTES & WALKS

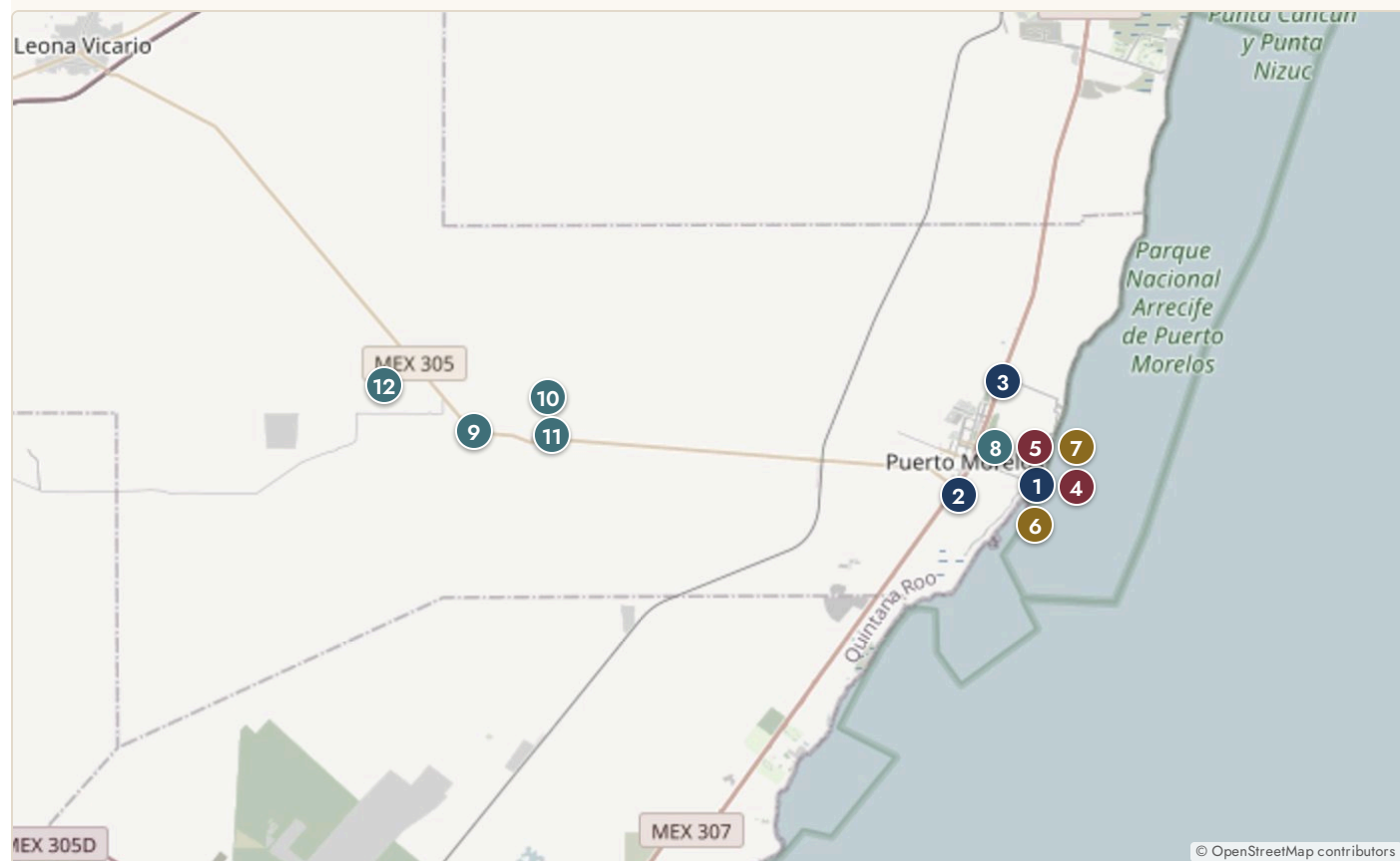
- 8 **Chankanaab** — About 8 km south of town: shore snorkelling, a botanical garden and a lagoon, about US\$25 (gear about US\$12–15). Opens 7:00 — be there before 9:00.
- 9 **Palancar & the reefs** — The world-famous wall reefs are reached by boat from the town dive shops; Palancar beach club at about km 19.5 makes a lunch stop close by.
- 10 **Punta Sur** — The southern tip: Celarain lighthouse and museum, a crocodile tower over Colombia Lagoon, the little El Caracol ruin and snorkelling. About US\$17–19, Mon–Sat 9:00–17:00, closed Sunday; bring food and cash.
- 11 **The east coast** — An empty, surf-pounded shore: swim only in sheltered Chen Río bay. Lunch at the cliff-top Coconuts or at Mezcalito's where the cross-island road meets the sea.



Ken Thomas · Public domain

6 AREA Puerto Morelos & the Cenote Route

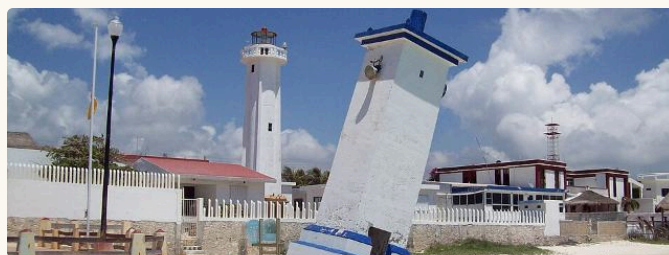
Thirty-five minutes north, Puerto Morelos is a small fishing village with a square, sandy side streets and a reef just 500 m offshore — a quiet day of snorkelling and lunch. Inland, the Ruta de los Cenotes towards Leona Vicario strings together a dozen jungle cenotes; you need a car or a taxi for the day.



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SIGHTS, RUINS & MUSEUMS

- 1 The square & the leaning lighthouse** — The Faro Inclinado on the beach by the square was tipped over by Hurricane Beulah in 1967 and left as it fell — the village's photo stop.
- 2 Jardín Botánico Dr. Alfredo Barrera Marín** — On Highway 307 just south of the junction: jungle trails, chicle trees, a reconstructed Maya house and a lookout tower. Bring repellent.
- 3 Croco Cun** — Just north on 307: guided walks among crocodiles, spider monkeys and deer — better than it sounds.



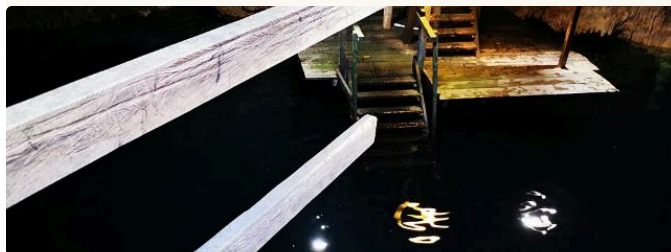
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RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 4 El Pirata** — On the square: casual fish tacos and cold beer while you wait for the snorkel boat.
- 5 Punta Corcho** — Seafood and ceviche on the beach north of the square, with a sea view.

SHOPPING & CRAFTS

- 6 **Alma Libre Bookstore** — On the square: a big English-language used bookshop — stock up for the month (hours vary by season).
- 7 **The craft market** — A short walk south of the square: hammocks and crafts, with far less pressure than Playa.



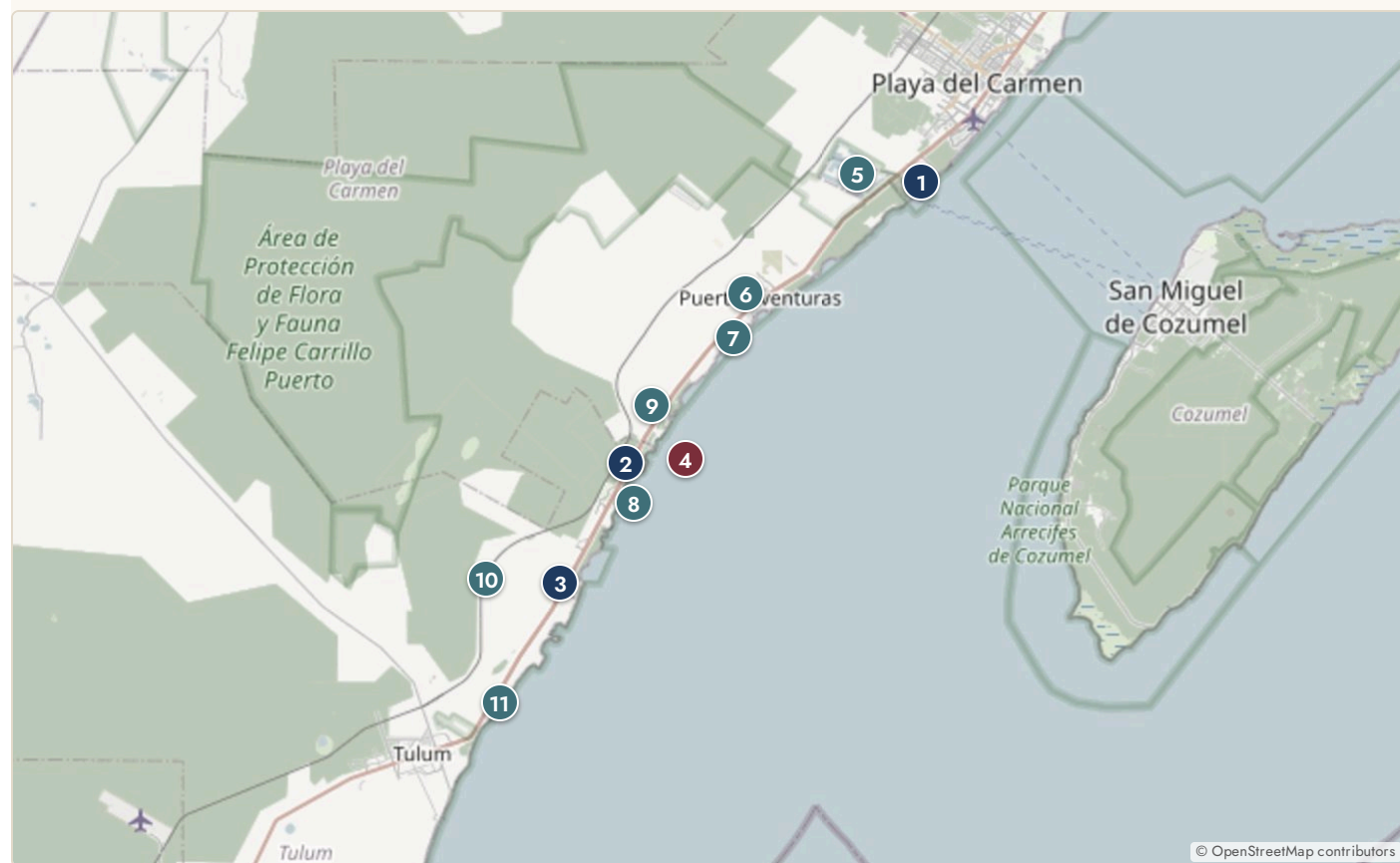
Wotancito · CC BY-SA 4.0

BEACHES, CENOTES & WALKS

- 8 **Reef snorkelling** — Boats leave from the beach by the pier for the national-park reef: about US\$38–45 for 2–4 hours and two stops. Ask whether the park fee is included; go in the calm morning.
- 9 **Verde Lucero** — Km 17 of the cenote road: an open cenote with a zip-line that drops you into the water. MXN 200; 9:00–18:00.
- 10 **Siete Bocas** — Km 20: a dim cave cenote with seven openings of light. MXN 300; 8:00–17:00; wear water shoes.
- 11 **Boca del Puma & Las Mojarras** — Adventure cenotes with zip-lines, platforms and ATV trails; Las Mojarras MXN 250 (950 with the ATV tour).
- 12 **Zapote & Kin Ha** — Zapote (MXN 300) for its strange bell-shaped rock formations; Kin Ha (MXN 430, 9:00–20:00) for late swims.

7 The Coast South: Xcaret to Akumal

South of Playa, Highway 307 runs past calm bays where green turtles graze on seagrass, theme parks built round underground rivers, and a jungle full of cenotes. It's best done as a string of colectivo stops — a cenote in the morning, the turtles at Akumal, lunch on the beach.



SIGHTS, RUINS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Xcaret & Xplor** — Six kilometres south: Xcaret's underground rivers, wildlife and nightly Mexico show (about US\$150–190), and Xplor's zip-lines and rafts next door (about US\$110–130). Book 1–3 weeks ahead for discounts; a long day.
- 2 **Centro Ecológico Akumal** — The non-profit on the bay explains the turtles, the reef and the rules — stop in before you swim.
- 3 **Xel-Há** — An all-inclusive natural park around a huge inlet — snorkel, float and eat all day. Pricey; buy online ahead.



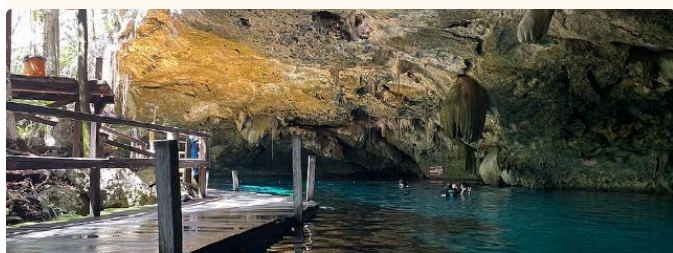
P.Lindgren · CC BY-SA 3.0

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 4 **La Buena Vida** — Half Moon Bay: a beach bar with swing seats for lunch after the turtles.

BEACHES, CENOTES & WALKS

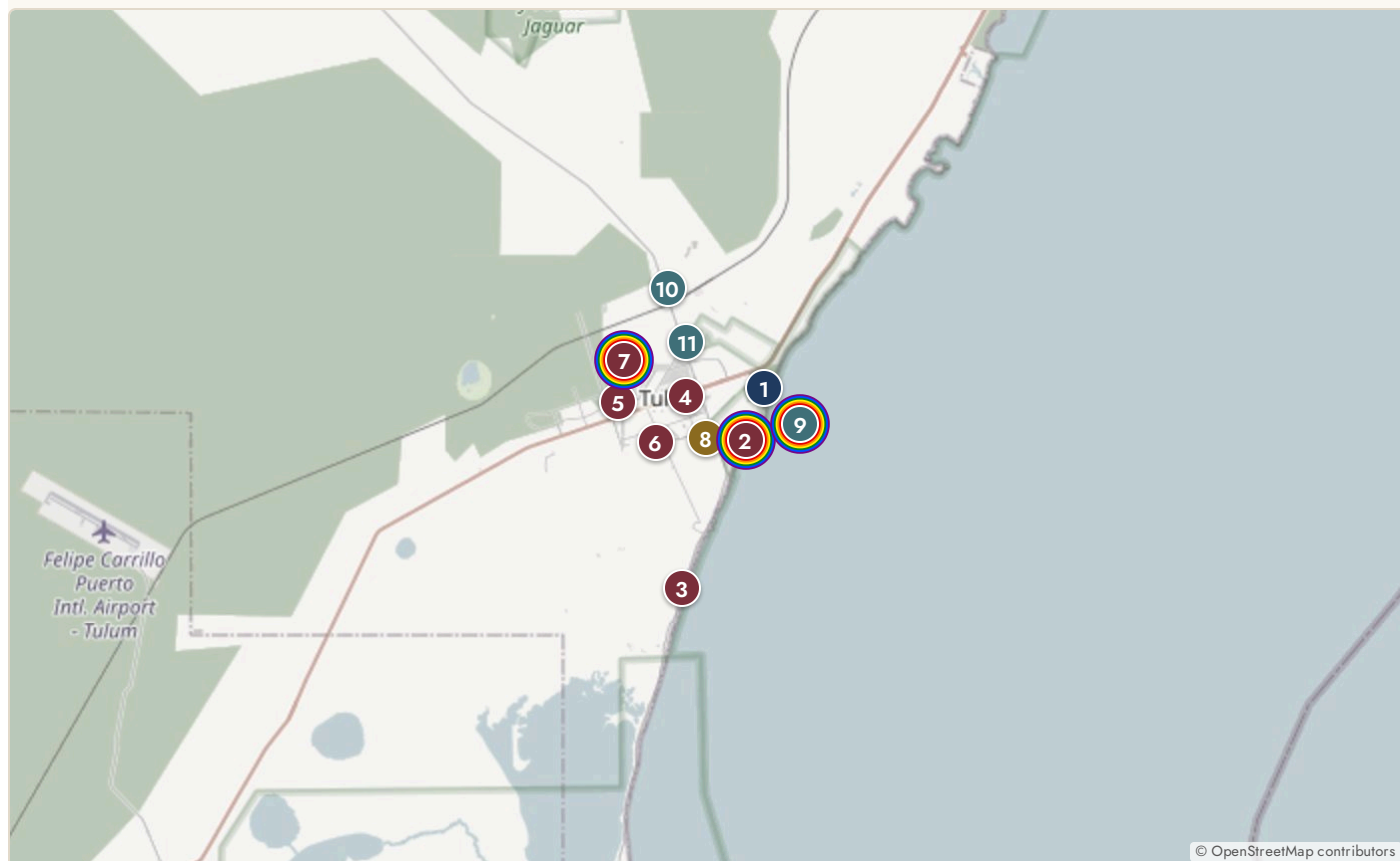
- 5 **Río Secreto** — Eight kilometres south: a guided walk-and-swim through a lit underground river of stalactites, from about US\$89. Book ahead.
- 6 **Cristalino, Azul & Jardín del Edén** — Three open cenotes side by side at about km 23: Cristalino for quiet swimming, Azul's shallow terraces and jumping rock, Jardín del Edén's big pool (closed Saturday). About MXN 150–450 each; go before 10:00.
- 7 **Xpu-Ha** — A long white beach down dirt roads off the highway; free public access, or a beach-club day pass (MXN 200–400, often credited to food).
- 8 **Akumal Bay turtles** — Green turtles graze a few metres from the beach. The protected zone requires a licensed guide (six people each) and a life vest, about US\$25–40 for 45 minutes; keep 3 m away. Go at 8:00–10:00.
- 9 **Yal-Kú lagoon** — North Akumal: a calm inlet where cenote water meets the sea, full of fish; 9:00–17:00, life vest included. Buy online.
- 10 **Dos Ojos** — Between Xel-Há and Tulum: two linked cavern cenotes with 60–80 m visibility — the best snorkel in the caves, from about MXN 400. Bring water shoes.
- 11 **Casa Cenote** — At Tankah: a mangrove-fringed cenote that connects under the road to the sea — kayak or snorkel with fish from both.



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8 AREA Tulum

An hour south, Tulum has cliff-top Maya ruins over turquoise water, a working pueblo with cheap taquerías, and a pricey, boho beach road in the jungle — two towns in one. Take the colectivo, ADO or train, rent bikes in town, and pick either the ruins and beach or the cenotes for a day.



- Sights, Ruins & Museums
- Cafés, Bakeries & Ice Cream
- Restaurants & Bars
- Markets & Food Shops
- Shopping & Crafts
- Beaches, Cenotes & Walks
- LGBTQ+-friendly

SIGHTS, RUINS & MUSEUMS

- 1 Tulum's ruins** — Enter through the Parque del Jaguar (put that in your map): since 20 July 2026 about MXN 265 in all (park 100 + ruins 165), cash; 9:00–17:00, last entry 16:00. An electric shuttle costs MXN 20. Go at opening.



Bruce Tuten from Savannah, Georgia, United State · CC BY 2.0

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 2 Mezzanine** LGBTQ+ — Thai food and cocktails on the cliff near the ruins; a gay-friendly sunset spot.
- 3 Ziggy's & Hartwood** — The beach road's two classics: Ziggy's beach club with live music at night, and Hartwood's wood-fired cooking — reserve well ahead.
- 4 Taquería Honorio** — Calle Satélite in the pueblo: cochinita and *lechón* tacos for breakfast and lunch, sold out by early afternoon.
- 5 Antojitos La Chiapaneca** — Av. Tulum at Satélite Sur: cheap al pastor tacos, open late.
- 6 Burrito Amor** — Av. Tulum: generous burritos with lighter, healthy fillings for a bike-day lunch.

- 7 Red Room**  — Tulum's steady gay bar, in the pueblo: drag and themed nights, Wed–Sun until late — only if you stay the night.

SHOPPING & CRAFTS

- 8 Avenida Tulum** — The pueblo's main street: ATMs, pharmacies, craft shops and bike rentals; a bike lane runs down Av. Cobá to the beach, 3–4 km.



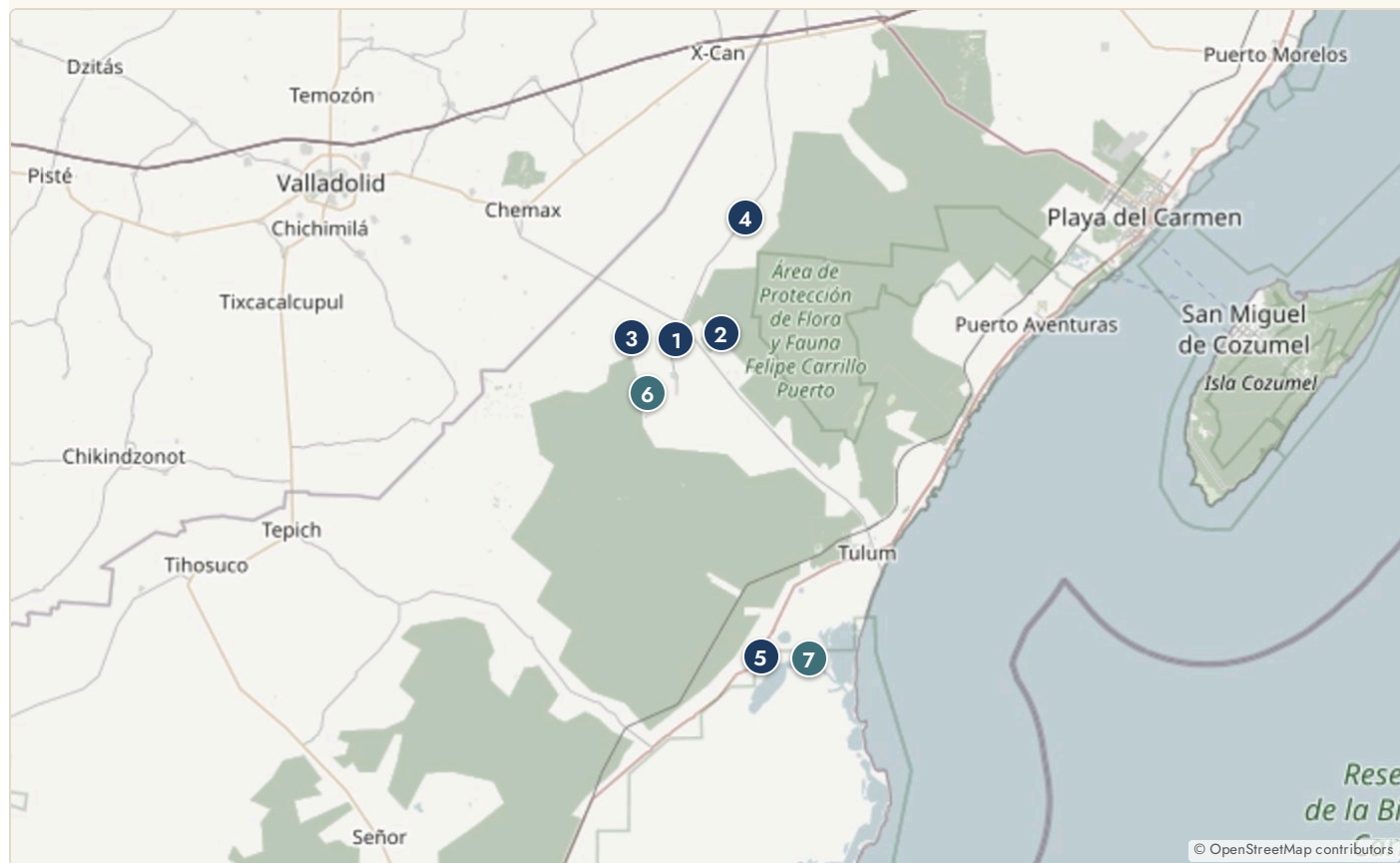
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BEACHES, CENOTES & WALKS

- 9 Playa Paraíso & Santa Fe**  — The beaches just south of the ruins, with the Castillo on the cliff behind — a favourite for gay couples' weddings. Park free at Playa Santa Fe.
- 10 Gran Cenote** — Four kilometres up the Cobá road (a bike ride): turtles, bats and caverns in clear water. About MXN 500, cash; opens about 8:00; shower first.
- 11 Calavera & Carwash** — Two smaller cenotes on the same road, about MXN 150–200 each: jump in through the “skull” holes of Calavera, or float among the lily pads of Carwash.

9 Cobá, Punta Laguna & Sian Ka'an

Cobá is a huge Maya city spread through shaded jungle beside lakes, linked by raised white roads you can cycle along — quieter and wilder than Tulum. South of Tulum, the Sian Ka'an biosphere reserve begins at Muyil, where you float down a canal the Maya dug a thousand years ago. A car, or ADO plus a local tour, makes both easy.



- Sights, Ruins & Museums ● Cafés, Bakeries & Ice Cream ● Restaurants & Bars ● Markets & Food Shops ● Shopping & Crafts
- Beaches, Cenotes & Walks ● LGBTQ+-friendly

SIGHTS, RUINS & MUSEUMS

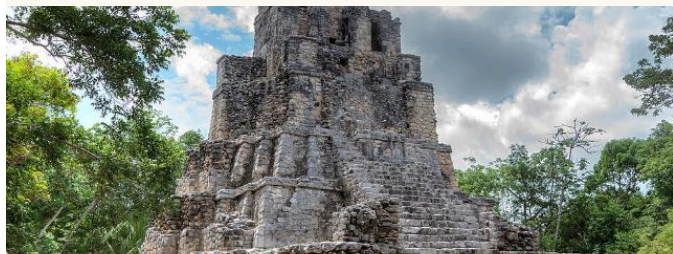
- 1 **Cobá** — INAH fee MXN 210 plus the ejido fee MXN 120 and parking 70 — cash only, and the nearest ATM is 40 minutes away. 8:00–17:00; arrive at opening, before the heat and the tour buses.
- 2 **Nohoch Mul** — Climbing the 42 m pyramid has reopened: 8:00–15:30 in groups of 15, 15 minutes on top, grippy closed shoes required. It stops in rain or wind; skip it with vertigo or bad knees.
- 3 **Bikes & bicitaxis** — Rent a bike inside (MXN 80–100) or hire a tricycle taxi for two (MXN 150–200) for the 2 km to Nohoch Mul, past the ball court, the Pinturas group and carved stelae.
- 4 **Punta Laguna** — Eighteen kilometres north: a Maya community reserve where local guides lead you to spider and howler monkeys, best early or late in the day.
- 5 **Muyil** — At Chunyaxché, 24 km south of Tulum: a small, empty jungle site with a boardwalk and lookout tower over the lagoons.



Bernard DUPONT · CC BY-SA 2.0

BEACHES, CENOTES & WALKS

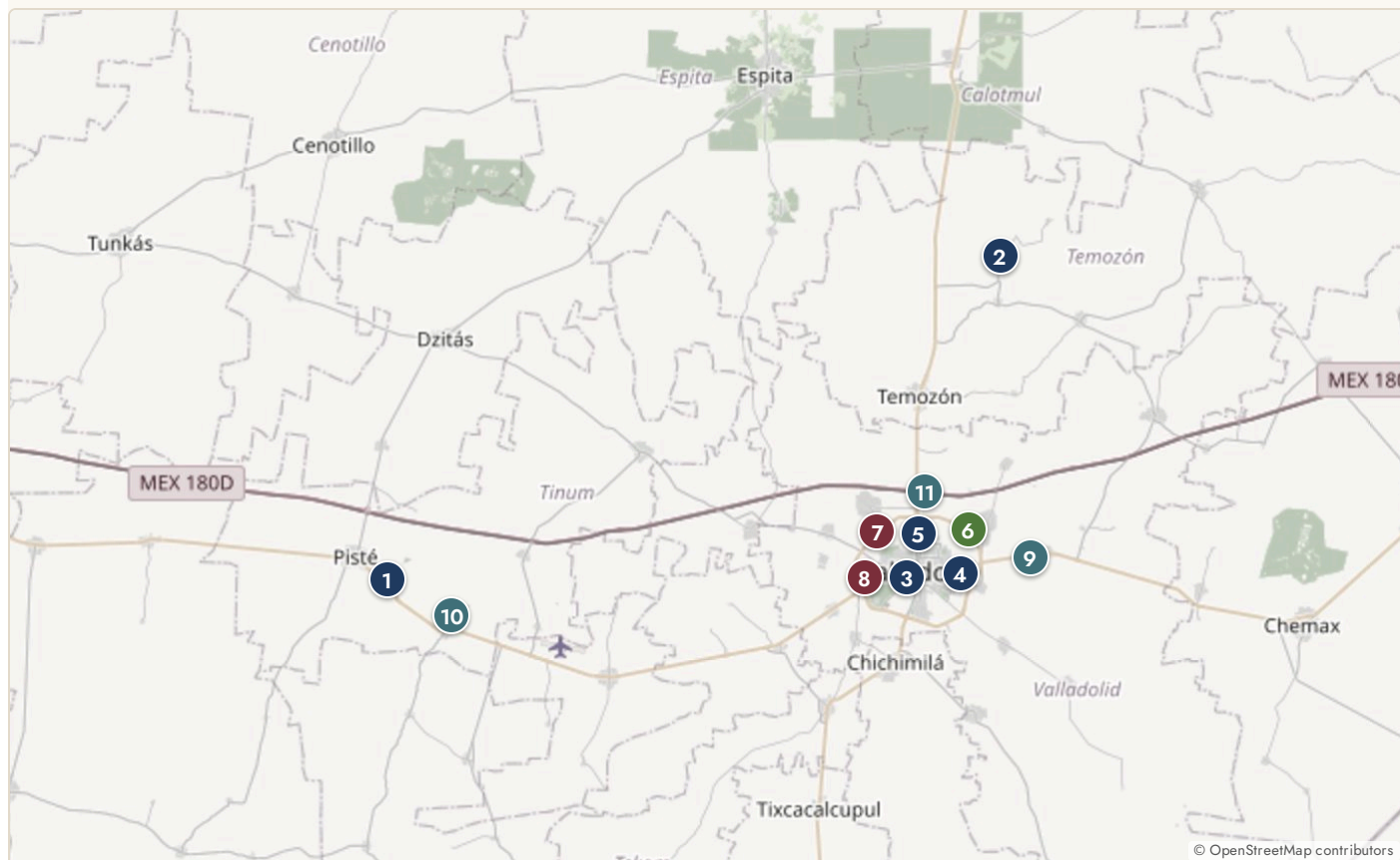
- 6 **Cobá's three cenotes** — Six kilometres south: Choo-Ha (a low cave), Tamcach-Ha (jumping platforms) and Multún-Ha (18 m down, the quietest). About MXN 100 each.
- 7 **The Muyil float** — A boat crosses two lagoons, then you float for 45 minutes down an ancient Maya canal in a life vest — one of the loveliest things on the coast. Arrive by 10:00; visitor numbers are capped.
- **Punta Allen** — The fishing village at the end of the Sian Ka'an road — 3+ hours each way on potholes. Go with a tour for dolphins, manatees, crocodiles and a snorkel.



Pierre Selim Huard · CC BY 3.0

IO Valladolid, Chichén Itzá & Ek Balam

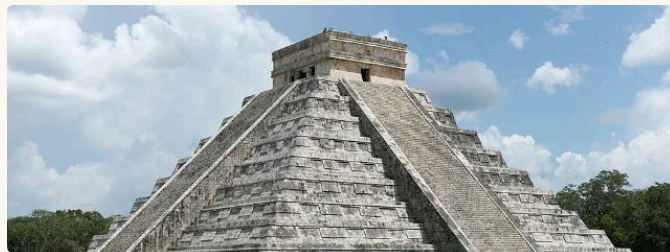
Two hours west, Valladolid is a pastel colonial town founded in 1543 on the Maya town of Zací — calm, affordable and at its best on the square in the evening. It's the base for Chichén Itzá at opening time, Ek Balam and the most photographed cenotes in Mexico: plan one night, two if you drive.



SIGHTS, RUINS & MUSEUMS

- 1 Chichén Itzá** — About MXN 676 for foreigners (federal plus state fee), cash is safest; 8:00–17:00, no climbing. Be at the gate at 8:00 to see El Castillo before the tour buses and the heat.
- 2 Ek Balam** — Thirty minutes north of Valladolid: the carved stucco jaguar-mouth doorway on the Acropolis is superb. MXN 691; ask at the gate whether climbing is allowed.
- 3 San Bernardino & the Calzada de los Frailes** — Walk the prettiest street in town to the 1560s Franciscan convent; its evening light show is projected on the facade (check the schedule).

- 4 Casa de los Venados** — A private colonial house filled with 3,000 pieces of Mexican folk art; tours usually at 10:00, by donation.
- 5 The main square** — San Servacio church, the ice-cream carts and the love-seat benches — sit here at dusk.



Daniel Schwen · CC BY-SA 4.0

MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- 6 **Mercado Municipal** — The morning market for *longaniza de Valladolid* sausage, fruit and cheap lunch counters.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 7 **Mesón del Marqués** — On the square: Yucatecan classics in a colonial courtyard; also a comfortable hotel.
- 8 **Yerbabuena del Sisal** — Near San Bernardino: fresh, light Yucatecan food and juices in a garden.



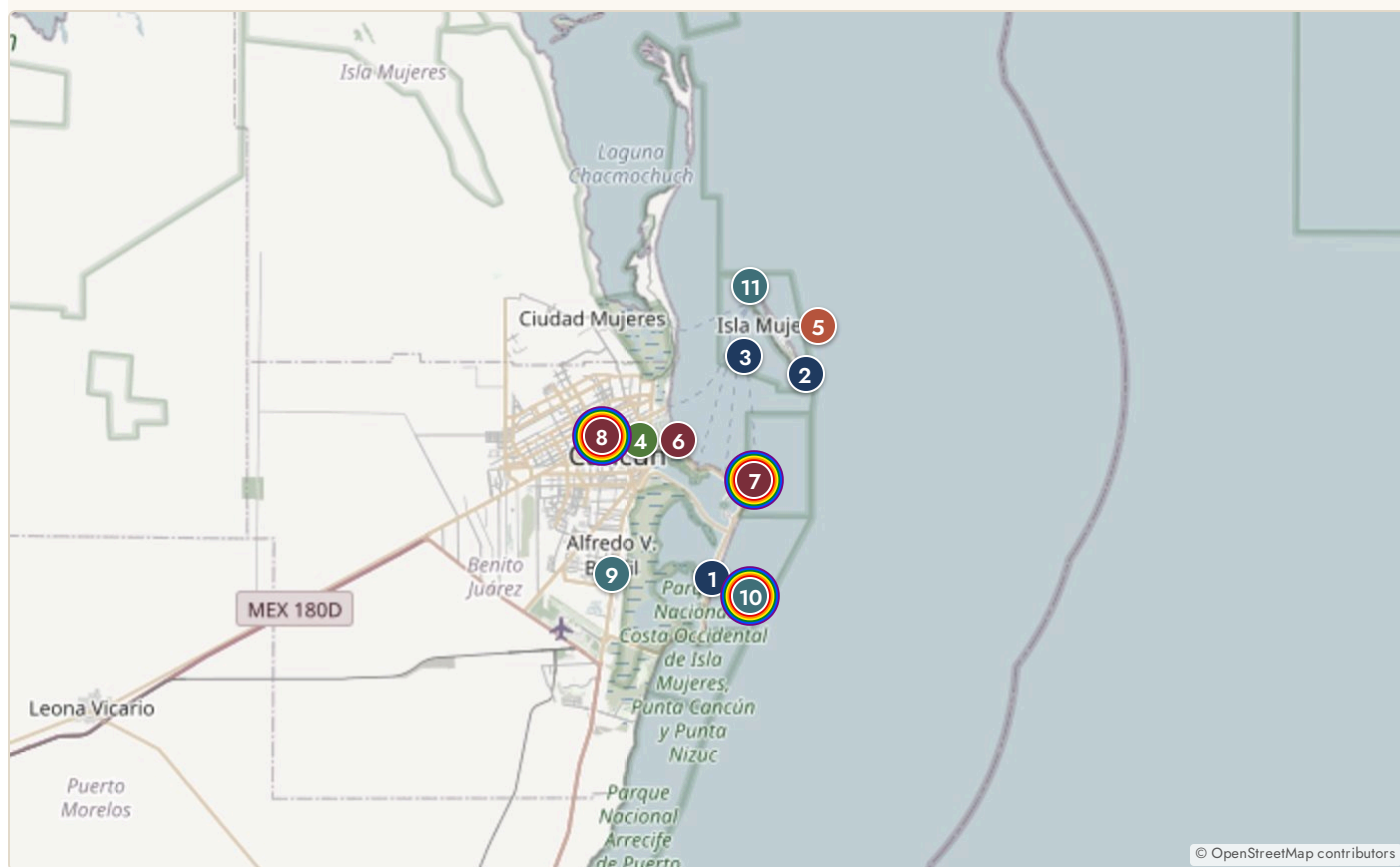
Erik Cleves Kristensen · CC BY 2.0

BEACHES, CENOTES & WALKS

- 9 **Cenote Suytún** — The stone platform in a cave lit by a single beam of sun — best around midday, and the beam fades as autumn goes on. About MXN 200.
- 10 **Ik Kil & Oxman** — Ik Kil, next to Chichén, is spectacular and crowded (about MXN 250–300); Oxman at Hacienda San Lorenzo has a rope swing and a food credit with the ticket.
- 11 **Cenote Zací** — In the middle of town: a half-open cenote with a restaurant, cheap and quiet in the late afternoon.

II Cancún & Isla Mujeres

An hour north by ADO, downtown Cancún is a real Mexican city of markets and street food, with the Maya museum and the gay bars; the Hotel Zone has the beaches. From Puerto Juárez, a 20-minute ferry reaches Isla Mujeres — a small, friendly and noticeably gay-friendly island with one of Mexico's best beaches. Stay a night.



- Sights, Ruins & Museums ● Cafés, Bakeries & Ice Cream ● Restaurants & Bars ● Markets & Food Shops ● Shopping & Crafts
- Beaches, Cenotes & Walks ● LGBTQ+-friendly

SIGHTS, RUINS & MUSEUMS

- 1 Museo Maya & San Miguelito** — In the Hotel Zone: a fine small museum of Quintana Roo archaeology with the San Miguelito ruins in its jungle garden. Closed Monday.
- 2 Punta Sur** — The island's southern cliffs: the ruins of a shrine to Ixchel and a sculpture garden over the sea. Hire a golf cart for the day (about MXN 900–1,200).
- 3 Tortugranja & Hacienda Mundaca** — The turtle farm and the overgrown 19th-century estate of a slave-trader-turned-pirate, both on the cart loop.



Bernard DUPONT · CC BY-SA 2.0

MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- 4 Parque de las Palapas & Mercado 28** — Downtown: evening street food and families in the Palapas; crafts and cheap Yucatecan lunches at Mercado 28.

CAFÉS, BAKERIES & ICE CREAM

- 5 **Mango Café** — The island's favourite breakfast, in the Salina Grande neighbourhood.



Andy Blackledge from Scottsdale, AZ, USA · CC BY 2.0

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 6 **La Habichuela** — The downtown classic: Caribbean-Maya cooking in a lantern-lit garden.
- 7 **The BackDoor**  — In the Hotel Zone: a Sunday drag brunch (14:00–17:00) that suits a couple better than the 2:00 club peak; nights Thu–Sat.
- 8 **11:11 Club**  — Downtown on Av. Tulum: the main gay club, with drag and go-go dancers Wed–Sun; late and young.

BEACHES, CENOTES & WALKS

- 9 **MUSA** — The underwater museum: hundreds of sculptures on the seabed, seen on a snorkel tour (about US\$50–75 plus a park wristband).
- 10 **Playa Delfines**  — The long public beach in the southern Hotel Zone, with the Cancún sign — and the unofficial gay beach.
- 11 **Isla Mujeres: Playa Norte** — Shallow, calm, turquoise water off soft white sand — swim, then stay for the sunset. Ultramar ferries from Puerto Juárez about every 30 minutes (about MXN 300–420 return).

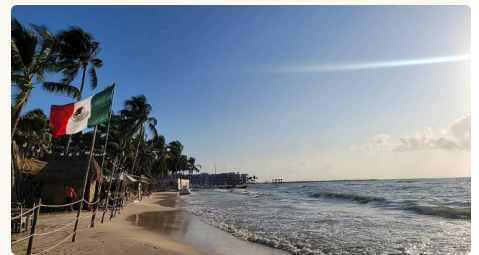
Quinta Avenida, from the pier to Calle 38

The whole length of Playa's pedestrian street in a leisurely morning — start early, before the cruise day-trippers, and finish with lunch and a swim at Calle 38.

- 1 Start: Parque Fundadores**
The Portal Maya, the church and the pier at 8:00.
- 2 Calle 2 & Calle 4**
Ah Cacao's hot chocolate; the gay strip, quiet by day.
- 3 Calle Corazón**
Galleries and design shops between Calle 12 and 14.
- 4 Constituyentes**
The Quinta calms down; Ah Cacao and Quinta Alegría on the corner.
- 5 Calle 28**
Down to the beach at Mamitas and the gay stretch.
- 6 Calle 34**
Axiote and La Perla Pixan — book for dinner.
- 7 Finish: Calle 38**
La Cueva del Chango or Amate 38, then the quieter beach.



Parque Fundadores — dronepicr · CC BY 2.0



On the beach — Erik Cleves Kristensen · CC BY 2.0

What to eat & drink

Yucatán cooking is its own cuisine — Maya, Spanish, Lebanese and Caribbean — built on achiote, sour orange, habanero and the underground pit, the *pib*.

DISH	WHAT IT IS	WHERE
Cochinita pibil	Pork slow-cooked in achiote and sour orange, with pickled red onion	Tacos and tortas at breakfast; Honorio in Tulum
Panuchos & salbutes	Fried tortillas — bean-stuffed or puffy — topped with turkey or pork	Rincón Yucateco; Valladolid market
Sopa de lima	Chicken broth with local lime and crisp tortilla strips	Amate 38; Mesón del Marqués
Poc chuc & relleno negro	Grilled sour-orange pork; turkey in burnt-chili sauce	Yucatecan restaurants
Tikin-xic	Whole fish in achiote, grilled in banana leaf	La Tarraya; beach restaurants
Tacos al pastor	Spit-roasted pork with pineapple — the Lebanese legacy	El Fogón; the Av. 30 stands
Aguachile & ceviche	Raw shrimp or fish “cooked” in lime and chili	Los Aguachiles; Puerto Morelos
Marquesitas	Crisp rolled crêpes with Edam cheese and Nutella	Evening carts on squares
Longaniza de Valladolid	Smoked sausage	Valladolid market
Drinks	Mezcal; Xtabentún (anise-honey liqueur); michelada; horchata; agua de chaya	La Perla Pixan; everywhere
Chocolate	The Maya drank cacao with chili — try it hot or iced	Ah Cacao



Cochinita pibil — El Nuevo Doge · CC0



Tacos — T.Tseng · CC BY 2.0

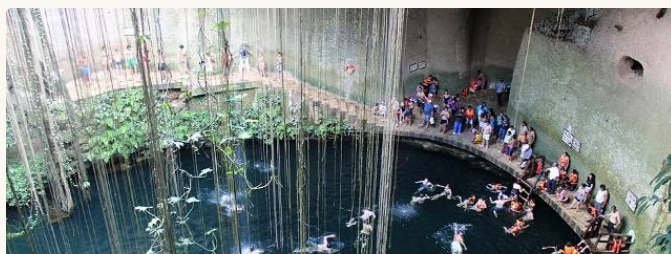
Cenotes at a glance

The peninsula has no rivers on the surface — only thousands of cenotes, windows into the world's longest underwater cave systems, sacred to the Maya as doors to Xibalbá. Shower first, no sunscreen, cash for the entry.

CENOTE	TYPE & WHERE	TIP
Chaak Tun	Cave, western edge of Playa	The closest; guided visit
Jardín del Edén, Azul, Cristalino	Open pools, km 23 south	Go before 10:00; Edén closed Sat
Dos Ojos	Cavern, near Xel-Há	Best cave snorkel, 60–80 m visibility
Casa Cenote	Mangrove, Tankah	Connected to the sea
Gran Cenote, Calavera, Carwash	Semi-open and cave, Tulum–Cobá road	Cycle from Tulum
Choo-Ha, Tamcach-Ha, Multún-Ha	Caves, near Cobá	About MXN 100 each
Verde Lucero, Siete Bocas	Open and cave, Puerto Morelos route	Zip-line into Verde Lucero
Suytún	Cave with a light beam, Valladolid	Midday for the beam
Ik Kil, Oxman, Zací	Open, Chichén and Valladolid	Ik Kil early; Zací in town



Cenote Suytún — Daniel Lobo · CC BY 2.0



Ik Kil — Shinya Suzuki · CC BY 2.0

Maya sites at a glance

The Maya built on this coast for 2,500 years; Tulum was still trading when the Spanish sailed by in 1518. Foreigners pay the full fee every day, and fees rose in 2026 — bring cash.

SITE	FROM PLAYA	FEE (MXN) & TIP
Xaman-Ha	Playacar, on foot	Free; small temples
Tulum	1 h, colectivo or train	About 265; opening time
Cobá	1 h 45, car or ADO	210 + 120 ejido; climb Nohoch Mul
Muyil	1 h 20, car	Small fee; add the canal float
San Gervasio	Cozumel	Shrine of Ixchel
Chichén Itzá	2 h 15	About 676; 8:00 sharp
Ek Balam	2 h 15	691; stucco jaguar doorway
Uxmal & the Puuc	From Mérida	586; Kabah 636



Ek Balam — Sharon Hahn Darlin · CC BY 2.0



Muyil — Tschips · CC BY-SA 3.0

Festivals by month

The coast’s calendar mixes Catholic saints, Maya traditions, carnival — and a growing Pride season in May and June.

MONTH	WHAT’S ON
October–November	Day of the Dead and Hanal Pixán (31 Oct–2 Nov): altars, costumes on the Quinta, Xcaret’s Festival de Vida y Muerte
November	Riviera Maya Jazz Festival on Mamitas beach — if it returns (not held since 2023)
December	Virgin of Guadalupe (12 Dec): torch runners on the highways; Christmas posadas
January	Mérida’s founding festival; Arena circuit party (late Jan–early Feb)
February	Carnival in Cozumel, Playa and Mérida (week before Ash Wednesday, 10 Feb 2027)
March	Spring equinox at Chichén Itzá — the serpent shadow on El Castillo; Easter week 21 Mar–4 Apr 2027
May	Sacred Maya Journey canoe crossing to Cozumel; Cancún Pride (2026: 16 May)
June	Playa del Carmen Pride (2026: 28 June); whale-shark season at Holbox (mid-May–mid-Sept)
July	Nuestra Señora del Carmen, the town’s patron (16 Jul)
August–October	Turtle hatchlings on the beaches; Independence Day (15–16 Sept)



Day of the Dead — Adan Tun Salazar · CC BY-SA 4.0



The Voladores — Adrián Cerón · CC BY-SA 4.0

Where to live for a month

North Centro & Little Italy (Calle 24–34, Av. 10–25)

Walk to Axiote, Choux Choux, DAC and Mega, both El Fogóns, the Calle 28 beach, Sirenas and Provenza, and the ADO terminals. Plenty of condos with pools. Against it: weekend bar noise near Calle 28–34 — choose a unit set back from the Quinta.

Zazil-Ha (Calle 38–48, near the sea)

The pick for a quiet month: leafy, residential, close to the beach and the Calle 38 restaurants, 10–15 minutes' walk to Centro. Against it: a taxi (MXN 60–80) to the bars on Calle 4 or 12.

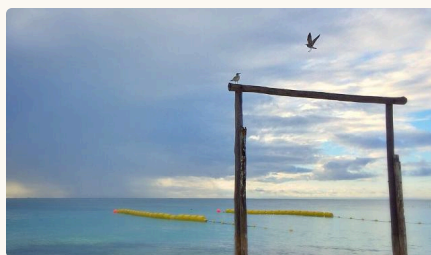
Playacar Phase I

Gated, green and safe, near the beach, the birds and the ruins, 10 minutes from the ferry. Against it: dead evenings, and Phase 2 needs taxis.

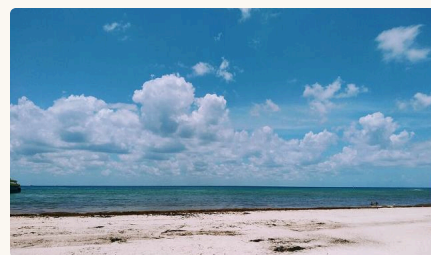
A 30-day rhythm: days 1–3 settling in — the beach, the Quinta, a first taco crawl on Av. 30; then two day trips a week with rest days between: Cozumel, the cenotes and Akumal, Puerto Morelos, Tulum, Cobá and Muyil. Around day 10, a night in Valladolid for Chichén Itzá at opening; around day 18, two or three nights in Mérida or Bacalar by train; a night on Isla Mujeres near the end, then fly home from Cancún. Keep one “nothing day” a week.



Playa del Carmen from the air — dronepicr · CC BY 2.0



The beach — Sharon Hahn Darlin · CC BY 2.0



Playacar — Ana Beatriz Vega González · CC BY-SA 4.0

Mérida, Bacalar, Holbox and the flamingo coast have their own chapters, starting on the next page.

Two- and three-day extensions

The Tren Maya and ADO put the whole peninsula within reach: the white city of Mérida, the seven-coloured lagoon at Bacalar, car-free Holbox, and flamingos on the north coast. Leave the big suitcase in Playa and travel light.



DESTINATION	GETTING THERE	BEST AS
Mérida, Uxmal & Izamal	Tren Maya 3 h 40 (about MXN 960) or ADO 4–4.5 h	2–3 nights
Bacalar	Tren Maya 3 h 45–4 h 35 or ADO about 4 h	2–3 nights
Holbox	Car 3–3.5 h to Chiquilá, then a 25-minute ferry	2 nights
Río Lagartos & Las Coloradas	Car 3–3.5 h via Valladolid	1 night

Mérida, Uxmal & Izamal



Andreia Pech · CC BY 2.0



Sybz · CC BY-SA 3.0

GETTING THERE The Tren Maya takes 3 h 40 to Mérida's Teya station (about MXN 960; 20 minutes by taxi to the centre); ADO takes 4–4.5 h to the centre. Izamal is on the train line, 3 h from Playa. A car helps for Uxmal and the Puuc.

A LITTLE HISTORY

Mérida was founded in 1542 on the Maya city of T'hó, and grew rich on henequen (sisal rope) around 1900 — hence the French-style mansions of Paseo de Montejo. Today it's the Yucatán's safe, cultured capital, with free music and dance every night of the week and the peninsula's most open gay scene.

THINGS TO DO

Gran Museo del Mundo Maya

The best Maya museum on the peninsula; MXN 150, closed Tuesday.

Uxmal & the Ruta Puuc

The Pyramid of the Magician (MXN 586), Kabah and Labná — a full day by car.

Paseo de Montejo & Palacio Cantón

Mansions by calesa, and the anthropology museum in a beaux-arts palace; Sunday mornings the avenue closes for bikes.

Izamal & a drag night

The yellow convent town (light show Thu–Sat 20:00, MXN 163); back in Mérida, Bernardette Show Bar or Farándula for cabaret drag.

Tips: Stay at the gay-owned Ochenta y Dos B&B in Santiago or Casa Lecanda. Sunday's Mérida en Domingo fills the Plaza Grande. The Gran Museo's evening light show is suspended for now.

Bacalar



Sharon Hahn Darlin · CC BY 2.0

GETTING THERE The Tren Maya reaches Bacalar in about 3 h 45–4 h 35 (about MXN 920–1,120); the station is outside town, so take a taxi. ADO takes about 4 h, a car 3.5–4 h via Tulum.

A LITTLE HISTORY

A Maya settlement, then Spanish Salamanca de Bacalar from the 1540s, with the Fuerte San Felipe built in 1729 against pirates and taken by the Maya in the Caste War. Today it's a slow, eco-minded lagoon town with an easy-going, queer-friendly traveller crowd.

THINGS TO DO

Sailing the Laguna de los Siete Colores

A shared sailboat to the Pirates' Canal, Bird Island and Cenote Esmeralda, about MXN 600–900.

Fuerte San Felipe

The pirate fort and museum above the water.

Los Rápidos

Float down a clear current past the lagoon's ancient stromatolites — never touch or stand on them.

Cenote Azul & a sunrise paddle

A 90 m-deep cenote with a restaurant; kayak from your hotel dock at dawn.

Tips: No sunscreen in the stromatolite zones. Stay on the water — Hotel Akalki's overwater cabins, or Rancho Encantado.

Holbox



Bruno Rijsman · CC BY-SA 2.0

GETTING THERE Drive about 3–3.5 h to Chiquilá and leave the car in a paid lot; 9 Hermanos and Holbox Express ferries cross about hourly, 6:00–21:00, in 25 minutes. Golf carts and bikes on the island.

A LITTLE HISTORY

A fishing island inside the Yum Balam reserve, settled in the 1800s, whose name means “black hole” in Maya. Sand streets, street art and a barefoot pace.

THINGS TO DO

Tres Islas

A boat to Isla Pasión, Bird Island and the Yalahau spring, about MXN 700–1,000.

Punta Cocos

Sunset — and bioluminescent plankton on dark, moonless nights.

Punta Mosquito

Wade across the sandbar to the flamingos.

Mangroves by kayak

Quiet channels full of herons.

Tips: The whale-shark season (mid-May to mid-September) is over for this autumn. Bring cash; ATMs run dry.

1 NIGHT · CAR VIA VALLADOLID

Río Lagartos & Las Coloradas



Adam Baker from Houston, TX · CC BY 2.0

GETTING THERE About 3–3.5 h from Playa by car via Valladolid and Tizimín; combine with a night in Valladolid.

A LITTLE HISTORY

A fishing village in a mangrove biosphere reserve on the Gulf, where thousands of flamingos feed from about November to March, and the salt works at Las Coloradas turn the lagoons pink.

THINGS TO DO

Flamingo boat

Two to three hours through the mangroves, with crocodiles and a clay bath, about MXN 2,000–3,000 per boat.

Las Coloradas

The pink salt lagoons on a short guided walk — no swimming.

Tips: A rural area — be discreet. Go early in the morning for the birds and the colour.

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Maps: © OpenStreetMap contributors. Geocoding: Photon (OpenStreetMap). Prices, hours and fares were checked in late September 2026; Tren Maya fares, ruin fees and ferry prices all changed during 2026, so confirm before you go. MXN amounts are approximate (about 13 MXN to the Canadian dollar).

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